

5 Malcolm X and Black Power

The Civil Rights Movement in the north

The Civil Rights Movement is often associated with the south; however, in the north, Black people still faced many problems:

- They could vote, but often lived in the poorest areas of cities (ghettoes).
- It was difficult for Black people to get a good education and good jobs.

The rise of Malcolm X and the Black Power movement saw a shift in focus towards these issues.

Malcolm X

Born: Malcolm Little in 1925. He later rejected his 'slave' surname and used 'X'.

Parents: Father murdered by white racists; mother sent to a psychiatric hospital.

- Whilst in prison for burglary, he joined the **Nation of Islam (NOI)**, a **militant** organisation influenced by Islam and **Black nationalism**.
- In a 1959 TV interview, he called white people 'collectively' evil.
- He expressed contempt for King and the idea of non-violence, echoing a growing belief that these methods had failed: inequality was clear to see in the ghettoes.
- He encouraged Black people to be proud of their identity and to defend themselves 'by any means necessary' against white attacks.
- NOI's membership grew to 30 000 members by 1963, at least in part due to his passionate campaigns. However, he became disillusioned with NOI and left in 1964, thereafter adopting a more tolerant, less militant outlook.
- He founded his own religious organisation – Muslim Mosque, Inc. (MMI) – as well as the Organization of Afro-American Unity (OAAU) to work with other civil rights organisations.
- He was assassinated by members of the NOI whilst giving a speech on 21 February 1965. Over 15 000 people paid their respects after his funeral.



▲ Malcolm X

The emergence of Black Power

Black people found a new way to express their anger with the emergence of the **Black Power** movement. Members talked of a social revolution to improve the lives of Black people in the USA.



Stokely Carmichael

Encouraging Black people to register to vote was one step. The next step was deciding who they should vote for.



▲ Stokely Carmichael

- In 1965, SNCC member Stokely Carmichael set up the Lowndes County Freedom Organization as a party to represent Black Americans; its symbol was a panther.
- In 1966, Carmichael was elected **Chair** of the SNCC. He encouraged supporters of Black Power to join and launched SNCC campaigns in the northern ghettoes.
- During the 1966 'March Against Fear', led by 'Ole Miss' student James Meredith, Carmichael made militant speeches and coined the phrase 'Black Power', which led many campaigners to adopt his more **radical** beliefs.
- In 1968, Carmichael left the SNCC. He was made honorary Prime Minister of the Black Panther Party in 1969.

The Black Panthers

The Black Panther Party for Self-Defense was formed in California in October 1966. It became one of the largest and most notorious of the Black Power groups.

It behaved like a political party, with a ten-point programme of demands, and a military visual style of black trousers, black leather jacket, top, and beret.	Members followed the police around in predominantly Black areas, and called for Black officials and police officers to serve Black communities.
Members gained media attention by marching to the state Capitol building carrying guns to protest a law banning people from carrying guns openly.	The Party carried out social work and campaigns, set up clinics on health, legal rights, and education, and had free breakfast programmes.
The Party demanded an end to police brutality against Black Americans, freedom for Black prisoners, and equal employment, housing, and education.	Members' intimidating appearance and demands made them a target for confrontations with the police and FBI infiltration, so the Party's influence rapidly declined.



Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

Nation of Islam militant
Black nationalism Black Power
Chair radical

REVISION TIP

You may see different interpretations of groups like the Black Panthers, some focusing on their provocative acts and others on their good works.

The 1968 Mexico Olympics

Black Power appeared on the world stage at the 1968 Olympic Games in Mexico.



▲ US athletes Tommie Smith (centre) and John Carlos (right) give the Black Power salute at their medal ceremony, at the 1968 Olympic Games

- During the US national anthem, two Black American medal-winners bowed their heads and raised an arm, each showing a black gloved fist: the salute used by many Black Power groups.
- Boos rang around the stadium and both athletes were suspended by the US Olympic team – but the Black Power salute became famous worldwide.
- Many young people were inspired to join the Black Power movement or adopt its more confrontational tactics.

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

- Which organisation did Malcolm X join whilst in prison?
- How were Malcolm X's views different to King's?
- What happened on 21 February 1965?
- Which organisation did Stokely Carmichael chair?
- What does 'Black Power' mean?
- Why was the 1968 Mexico Olympics significant for the idea of 'Black Power'?
- When and where was the Black Panther Party formed?
- What was the full name of the Black Panthers?
- What social programmes did the Black Panthers set up?
- Which organisations targeted the Black Panthers?
- Why did some view the Black Panthers as intimidating?

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- The Nation of Islam (NOI)
- Malcolm X rejected non-violence, believing that white people were 'collectively' evil
- Malcolm X was assassinated by members of the Nation of Islam
- SNCC
- Black people should be proud of their heritage and stand up for themselves without white help
- Two Black athletes gave the Black Power salute when receiving their medals, gaining widespread media attention for the cause
- October 1966, California
- The Black Panther Party for Self-Defense
- Clinics to advise on health, legal rights, and education; free breakfast programmes
- The police and the FBI
- They wore black, military-style uniforms, carried guns, and challenged the police

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

- What triggered the Montgomery Bus Boycott?
- How did opponents of desegregation try to disrupt the Freedom Rides?
- Why did the SCLC try to organise a campaign in Selma?

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- Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat on a bus for a white man, and was arrested; this caused outrage
- Firebombed the bus at Anniston; dragged Riders off buses and beat them; beat them when the buses stopped; Riders were arrested
- Selma was predominantly Black but had the lowest rate of Black voter registration in Alabama

Practice

5

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: Huey Newton, one of the founders of the Black Panthers, posing for a photograph in 1968 wearing the uniform adopted by the group.



SOURCE TIP

You should scrutinise visual sources as thoroughly as written sources. It is inaccurate to dismiss cartoons as exaggerated, drawings as made-up, and to accept photographs as 100% reliable. Use your contextual knowledge and study the details depicted carefully before answering any visual source-based questions.

- Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about the Black Panther Party. (4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

- | | |
|------------------------|--|
| (i) What I can infer: | Details in the source that tell me this: |
| (ii) What I can infer: | Details in the source that tell me this: |

- Explain why the Black Power movement became popular. (12)

- You **may** use the following in your answer:
- slow progress in the campaign for civil rights
 - Malcolm X
- You **must** also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

Don't just describe the society or situation in the question; be sure to *explain why*. Consider how social, economic, political, and cultural factors led to the result described in the question. One way to do this is to look for short-term triggers, medium- and long-term reasons, and link them together.



6 The Civil Rights Movement, 1965-75

The riots of 1965-68

Growing frustration among Black people that their economic situation was not improving boiled over from 1964. Riots in cities across the USA occurred due to unemployment and poor housing, combined with the uncompromising language of Black Power.

From 1964 to 1968, there were over 500 separate riots, in which:

- almost 200 people lost their lives, and thousands were injured
- over a billion dollars of property damage was recorded by insurance companies.

There were four major riots:

- In New York City in July 1964, police triggered one by shooting a young Black man, two weeks after the Civil Rights Act and the month after the Mississippi murders.
- After Selma, a violent arrest sparked another riot in Los Angeles in August 1965.
- Major riots followed in Chicago and Cleveland (1966), and Newark and Detroit (1967).

	1964	1965	1966	1967	1968
Riots	11	11	53	158	289
No. days	34	20	109	408	739
Killed	2	35	11	83	66
Injured	996	1,132	525	2,801	5,302
Arrested	2,917	4,219	5,107	17,011	31,680
Arson attacks	238	3,006	812	4,627	6,041

▲ 1964-68 riot statistics, compiled by Robert Margo, ResearchGate

1 Police action

- Rioting was often triggered by police action: police shot 65 Black people (27 in the back, 25 unarmed) between 1963 and the 1965 Los Angeles riot.

2 Local responses

- Within local communities, there were minor attacks on white properties (e.g. stores that discriminated).
- Over 80% of participants were young Black men.

3 Escalating violence

- Attacks led to increased violence and looting.
- There were casualties, both Black and white, but most were Black people shot by white police officers or soldiers.

4 Restoring order

- The military was brought in to restore order.
- Reforms were promised; King and the SCLC, and President Johnson, agreed on the need for action.

The Kerner Report, 1968

In July 1967, President Johnson ordered an enquiry to investigate the causes of the riots.

In February 1968, the Kerner Report concluded that: 'Our nation is moving toward two societies, one Black, one white – separate and unequal.'

Over two million Americans bought copies of the report.

The Kerner Report:

- blamed 'white racism' for the riots
- criticised unfair police treatment and brutality for worsening the riots
- accused the media of exaggerating the scale of the riots
- stated that the government needed to listen to Black communities, and provide more aid to repair the damage done by racism.

King's campaign in the north

After the success of the 1965 Voting Rights Act, King decided to focus the SCLC on working towards economic rights for urban Black people.

1966	January: King announces the Chicago Freedom Movement to show that non-violence can still work. It targets housing and jobs.	Demonstrations and marches start to build momentum.
	July: A major riot breaks out, damaging King's position.	Later marches target all-white areas, but the public is much less supportive. Marchers are met by violence and hostility.
	August: The Mayor of Chicago reaches an agreement with King about housing.	The Chicago Freedom Movement is largely unsuccessful. The agreement is ignored.
1967	King plans the Poor People's Campaign, in Washington, D.C., for all people – Black or white.	
1968	4 April: King is assassinated by James Earl Ray, a white man, on his hotel balcony.	Rioting in 200 towns across the USA, with 40 killed, thousands injured, and 27 000 arrests in five days.
	11 April: A Civil Rights Act is rapidly passed, covering housing, civil rights workers, and increasing punishments for rioting.	White support for the Civil Rights Movement declines due to Black Power, the severity of the riots, and a perception that the fight has been won.
	19 June: The Poor People's Campaign marches to Washington.	The campaign fails. The SCLC leadership and protesters argue.
1969	The SNCC drops 'non-violent' from its name.	The SNCC loses many original members.

The extent of progress in civil rights by 1975

Nixon replaced Johnson as President in 1969. Although he occasionally spoke up for civil rights, he tried to appeal to a 'silent majority' in the south and north who wanted an end to civil rights protest.

Considerable progress had been made by the Civil Rights Movement by 1975. However, life in the USA was still profoundly different for Black Americans compared to white Americans.

Political rights by 1975	Economic rights by 1975	Social rights by 1975
✓ Black and white Americans had the same political rights, protected by federal law. ✓ 15 Black members of Congress. ✓ Cities such as Newark, Detroit, Los Angeles and Washington had Black mayors. ✓ The 1970 Voting Rights Act banned literacy tests. ✗ The percentage of elected Black officials was still not close to the percentage of Black people in the country.	✓ Nixon encouraged Black businesses and home ownership. ✓ More middle-class Black Americans. ✓ Black Americans closed the gap in average pay. ✗ Black people twice as likely to be unemployed. ✗ The average Black household had only 60% of the income of the average white household. ✗ Black Americans were three times more likely to live in poverty.	✓ The <i>New York Times</i> declared 'The South's public schools are now the most desegregated in the country'. ✓ 'Jim Crow' state laws had been abolished across the USA. ✗ Life expectancy for Black people was five years less than for white people. ✗ More Black university graduates, but white people were twice as likely to hold a degree. ✗ In 1972, almost two-thirds of Black children were in majority-Black schools.

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions	Answers
1 Where did major riots occur during 1964–68?	New York; Los Angeles; Chicago/Cleveland; Newark/Detroit
2 What was a common trigger for the 1960s race riots?	Police action: US police shot 65 Black people between 1963 and the 1965 Los Angeles riot
3 When was the Kerner Report published?	February 1968
4 What did the Kerner Report conclude?	That the USA was 'moving towards two societies, one Black, one white – separate and unequal'
5 Which campaigns did King plan in 1966 and 1967, and which cities did they focus on?	1966: the Chicago Freedom Movement, Chicago; 1967: the Poor People's Campaign, Washington, D.C.
6 What happened after King's assassination?	Rioting in 200 towns across the USA, with 40 killed, thousands injured, and 27 000 arrests in five days
7 What key areas did the 1968 Civil Rights Act address?	Housing, workers' civil rights, and punishments for rioting
8 How did the riots impact support for the Civil Rights Movement?	They reduced support for the Civil Rights Movement, particularly from white Americans
9 How many Black members of Congress had been elected by 1975?	15
10 How comparable were the poverty rates for Black and white Americans by 1975?	Black Americans were three times more likely to live in poverty
11 How many Black children were still in majority-Black schools in 1972?	Almost two-thirds

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions	Answers
1 What did the Supreme Court decide in <i>Brown v. Topeka</i> , and in which year?	To overturn <i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> (1896) because separate educational facilities were unequal; 1954
2 Why was Mississippi targeted in the Freedom Summer?	It was seen as the most segregated state; only 7% of the Black population were registered to vote
3 How were Malcolm X's views different to King's?	Malcolm X rejected non-violence, believing that white people were 'collectively' evil

Exam-style questions

Study Sources A and B.

- 1 How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the importance of Martin Luther King to the campaign for civil rights in the north USA? Explain your answer, using Sources A and B and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

Source A: Stokely Carmichael speaking at the University of California, Berkeley, 29 October 1966, to an audience of 14 000 people.



Source B: From an interview given in 1989 by Albert Raby of the Coordinating Council of Community Organizations of Chicago.

... the movement was at a low ebb when we invited Dr. King to come to Chicago. ... his promise to come was re-energizing to the movement. Ah, it created, brought back the coalition in the city, and I think reactivated us all. ... we had dissipated I think, most of our energy at that point. ... it re-energized the entire movement and allowed us to come back, ah, as a coalition, to form around him, and to start again.

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the importance of Martin Luther King to the campaign for civil rights in the north USA.

- 2 What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

EXAM TIP

It is not enough to simply state a difference. In order to reach the higher level, you must show how the interpretations support your answer.

Interpretation 1: An adapted extract from *The Civil Rights Movement* by historian Mark Newman, published in 2004.

King agreed with Carmichael that blacks needed to develop group strength and achieve bargaining power. King also regarded the ghettos as internal colonies exploited by white capitalists. King's increasing radicalism developed from his shocked realisation that racism deeply pervaded the entire nation, and from his opposition to the Vietnam War.

Interpretation 2: An adapted extract from *The American Dream* by historian Esmond Wright, published in 1996.

By the late 1960s, organizations such as the NAACP, King's SCLC, and SNCC faced increasingly strong challenges from new militant organizations. The Panthers' strategy of 'picking up the gun' reflected the feelings of many inner city blacks. A series of major 'riots' erupted during the last half of the 1960s as civil rights reforms did not address the problems faced by millions of poor blacks.

- 3 Suggest **one** reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the importance of Martin Luther King to the campaign for civil rights in the north USA. You may use Sources A and B to help explain your answer. (4)
- 4 How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the importance of Martin Luther King to the campaign for civil rights in the north USA? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16)

